

**Department of World Languages and Cultures
Iowa State University**

M.A. in Anthropology Program Handbook

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1. Program Overview and Outcomes

The Department of World Languages and Cultures offers a Master of Arts degree with a major in Anthropology. The program provides students with advanced training in cultural anthropology, biological anthropology, and archaeology with the goal of preparing them for additional graduate study or professional work in anthropology and related fields. Students are required to do original field, archival, or laboratory research that will result in a scholarly thesis or creative component.

Students who have completed the MA in Anthropology will be able to:

- Demonstrate effective oral and written communication skills consistent with the focus of the graduate program.
- Demonstrate comprehensive understanding of scholarly literature in the area of study.
- Conduct qualitative and/or quantitative research via appropriate acquisition, analysis, and reporting of data.
- Articulate research objectives that, when met, will lead to significant contributions to the field of study.

2. Admissions

Applications to the program are accepted on a rolling basis. However, to guarantee consideration for Spring semester admission, applications should be submitted no later than October 1, and for Fall semester admission, no later than January 15. Applicants must submit a copy of their academic records (transcripts), GPA from previous undergraduate and graduate degrees, a statement of purpose, and three letters of recommendation. The statement of purpose should briefly outline the applicant's research interests and mention current anthropology faculty with whom the student would like to work.

The program does not require GRE scores. Applicants who have a GPA in their previous undergraduate or graduate degree that is at or below a 3.0 (out of 4.0) may be offered restricted admission. Applicants whose native language is not English must also demonstrate proficiency in English through examination (see 1.3.3 of the Graduate College Handbook for the Graduate College's approved testing methods and minimum acceptable scores, <https://www.grad-college.iastate.edu/handbook/chapter1-admissions>).

All applications will be reviewed by the Anthropology Graduate Faculty in consultation with the DOGE. The Graduate Program Committee (made up of the Anthropology Graduate Faculty) will vote to accept/decline each applicant. Upon a successful application, each student should be assigned a specific faculty member as their provisional primary mentor ("major professor"). Student and faculty member should be in contact before the first semester begins.

3. Financial Support

A limited number of Teaching Assistantship (TA) and Research Assistantship (RA) positions are awarded each year to incoming and continuing students. TAs and RAs receive a bi-monthly stipend and partial tuition and fee waiver. TAs either assist with or teach undergraduate courses. RAs assist the faculty member who employs them on specified research tasks. TA and RA positions are limited and are awarded to eligible students with the requisite qualifications for assisting or teaching

specific courses or assisting on specific research projects. Students applying to the program indicate their interest in TA or RA positions on their application forms. Continuing students should notify the DOGE of their interest in a TA position by the first week of the semester prior to the year they would like to be considered for TA funding.

4. Degree Program and Requirements

In order to complete the MA degree in Anthropology, students must complete required coursework, conduct original research, and write a scholarly thesis or complete a creative component, which must be approved by their Academic Plan Committee through a final oral examination. The Graduate College requires that students have a cumulative GPA of at least 3.0 to graduate. Competence in statistics or a methodology relevant to the student's program of study must also be demonstrated. Students are required to do original field, archival, or laboratory research that will result in a scholarly thesis or creative component. Students are expected to complete the degree within three years. Under extenuating circumstances, the Graduate Program Committee in consultation with the DOGE may choose to provide a student with additional time to finish.

4.1. Program of Study

In their first semester of the program, students should form their Academic Plan Committee) and submit the names of members to the Graduate College in Workday (https://iastate.service-now.com/esc?id=kb_article&sysparm_article=KB0025058). Students assigned to specific faculty members upon admission should work with those faculty members to identify the members of their Academic Plan Committee. The DOGE will assist all other students in identifying potential faculty for their Academic Plan Committee.

The Academic Plan Committee consists of a major professor, who must be a member of the anthropology program graduate faculty, and who chairs the student's Academic Plan Committee. Students also may opt to have co-major professors, in which case at least one of the co-major professors must be a member of the anthropology graduate faculty. The Academic Plan Committee must include at least two additional members, one of whom must be from the anthropology graduate faculty and one of whom must be from outside the anthropology graduate major. Students should seek outside members of the committee whose research expertise is relevant to the student's research project or creative component but offers a different disciplinary perspective on the subject. If the student is pursuing a graduate minor, graduate certificate, or second major, then the outside committee member should be from that minor, certificate, or major program.

Once a student has identified the members of their Academic Plan Committee and those members have agreed to serve on the committee, the student should work in consultation with the Academic Plan Committee to outline an academic plan. Once the student and Academic Plan Committee have agreed on the academic plan, the student must submit the academic plan to the Graduate College in Workday (https://iastate.service-now.com/esc?id=kb_article&sysparm_article=KB0023078). It is likely that there will be changes necessary to this plan over the course of the program. This plan can be revised at any time in Workday, but final revisions must be submitted to the Graduate College **and** be approved by the

student's Academic Plan Committee by the academic plan approval deadline in order to apply for program completion. Current deadlines for graduation requirements can be found here (under "Important Deadlines"): <https://www.grad-college.iastate.edu/student#deadlinesandevents> .

4.2. Course Requirements

Students are required to take at least 34 credits to graduate with an MA in Anthropology with the thesis option; 30 credits with a non-thesis option. Courses in the anthropology graduate major must be at the 4000-, 5000-, or 6000-level to count towards this total. Courses in programs or departments outside of the anthropology graduate major at the 4000-level can be counted towards this total.

All students please note: students are required to take 9 credit hours per semester to be considered a full-time student. **International Students please note:** students "whose native language is not English and who do not have a bachelor's or advanced degree from ISU or a U.S. institution, or do not meet the TOEFL or IELTS exemption score range, must take the English Placement Test at the beginning of their first semester of enrollment" (Graduate College Handbook 4.4.3, <https://www.grad-college.iastate.edu/handbook/chapter4-degrees>).

4.2.1 All students in the anthropology graduate major are required to take two **core courses**, which are designed to expose students to the major issues and contemporary thinking in both social scientific and natural scientific approaches to the study of anthropology:

- **Anthropology 5030:** Biological Anthropology & Archaeology
 - **Anthropology 5100:** Theoretical Dimensions of Cultural Anthropology
- Students should take both of these courses in their first year in the program.

4.2.2. All students in the anthropology graduate major are required to take an appropriate methods course such as:

- **Anthropology 5310:** Ethnographic Methods or **Anthropology 5190:** Skeletal Biology
- **Anthropology 5260:** Design Ethnography
- **Statistics 5101:** Statistical Methods for Data Analysis
- **Community & Regional Planning 4510/5510:** Introduction to Geographic Information Systems

The methods requirement should be completed in the first year. In consultation with the Academic Plan Committee, the DOGE will review any requests for courses not on the above list that students would like to count towards the methods requirement.

4.2.3. In their second year, all students in the anthropology graduate major must take at least four credits of either **Anthropology 5990:** Creative Component (for the non-thesis option) or **Anthropology 6990:** Research (for the thesis option).

4.2.4. In addition to the above courses, students must take at least **9 additional credits of 4000- or 5000- level** anthropology courses. Beyond the program's required courses, students are encouraged to take courses outside of the department that

contribute to the development of their area of concentration and/or independent study courses that focus on their research topic.

- 4.2.5.** Independent Study Courses should focus on topics not otherwise taught in regular courses. For the protection of the student and the instructor, student and instructor should complete and sign an Independent Study Course form (see Appendix). The general expectation is that faculty and student meet every two weeks to discuss the topic and student questions. A syllabus for the course, with a preliminary agreement on outcomes, topics addressed, and readings should be agreed upon no later than the first week of the semester.

4.3. Thesis and Creative Component Requirements

All students in the program must write a scholarly thesis or complete a creative component, both of which should be based on original research. This thesis or creative component and the research on which they are based represent the most significant means through which students develop and demonstrate their knowledge of a particular topic within a subfield of anthropology. Students will work with their major professors and members of their Academic Plan Committee to identify an appropriate topic for their research, a clear question for guiding their research, an ethical and anthropologically appropriate method for studying the question, and potential subjects, sites, collections, or archives for their research. A thesis or creative component is considered complete when it has been approved by the Academic Plan Committee and the Graduate College.

Students will likely choose whether to do a thesis or creative component based on their career goals after the MA degree. Students who wish to continue their graduate education in a PhD program in Anthropology or a related field may elect to write a thesis. Students who wish to work in the private or public sectors or do non-profit work after graduating, may choose a creative component. All students must have a research proposal approved by their Academic Plan Committee and must also receive official approval for their project from all relevant university ethics and safety review boards before beginning work on their thesis or creative component.

- 4.3.1. Research Proposal:** Once a student has identified a research topic in consultation with the Academic Plan Committee, the next step is for the student to write a proposal that includes, but is not limited to: a) the student's research question; b) the purpose and significance of the proposed research; c) the relevant existing literature; d) a discussion of the methodology the student will use to research the question; and, e) a proposed timeline for the research. The student will work on this proposal in consultation with the major professor, who will provide critical feedback on areas of the proposal in need of improvement. For a thesis, the proposal should reflect on the contribution to scholarship. For a creative component, the project should reflect a significant contribution to an organization, an institution, or the public; the proposal should reflect on this contribution. Once the student and major professor have agreed on a finalized draft of the proposal, the student will submit the proposal to the Academic Plan Committee for review. Research proposals should be submitted to the Academic Plan Committee before the end of the student's first year in the program. The Academic Plan Committee must approve the proposal before the student can proceed with research for the thesis.

- 4.3.2. Responsible research requirements:** All research conducted by students at Iowa State University is subject to the rules and requirements established by the Office of Research Ethics (<https://www.compliance.iastate.edu>). Students should also review the American Anthropological Association's Code of Ethics (<https://americananthro.org/about/anthropological-ethics/>).

Students may not initiate any human subjects research until they have received official approval from the IRB for their specified research project and methodology. Failure to comply will render any data collected null and void for use in the thesis and may lead to the student's dismissal from the program and/or expulsion from the university. All students conducting research with human subjects must first complete an online training certification (<https://www.compliance.iastate.edu/committees/irb/irb-training>). Copies of this certification must be submitted to the Academic Plan Committee. Students must then obtain approval from Iowa State's Institutional Review Board (IRB) (<https://www.compliance.iastate.edu/committees/irb/review>).

Students working with animal subjects or conducting laboratory research should carefully consult the requirements for such research with their major professors in order to **ensure that all requisite trainings and reviews by the Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC), Environmental Health and Safety (EHS), or the Radiation Safety Committee (RSC) are complete before thesis research begins.**

- 4.3.2.1 Thesis:** Theses are expected to be based on original, empirical research. Analysis should be clearly grounded in existing, current anthropological literature and a methodology appropriate to the discipline. The final thesis should be of a high academic quality. As noted above, students should not begin researching and writing the thesis until their research proposal has been approved by the Academic Plan Committee and the relevant ethics review board(s).

There is no specified required length of the thesis, but most theses submitted by students in the program are between fifty and one hundred double-spaced pages, inclusive of notes, references, and appendices. Students should consult with their major professor to determine the style that is most commonly used in their specified subdiscipline (e.g., Chicago vs. MLA vs. APA). Theses must adhere to the Graduate College formatting guidelines (<https://www.grad-college.iastate.edu/student/Thesis-Dissertation>). Students should submit their thesis to their Academic Plan Committee at least two weeks before the scheduled date of the Final Oral Examination.

- 4.3.2.2 Creative Component:** A creative component project can take a number of forms, depending on the student's interest and post-graduation goals. The project should apply anthropological methods and theory to a substantial practical problem. For example, students may choose to

design a community engagement project, test a new methodological tool in an applied setting, experiment with ethnographic writing, or provide input on an anthropological problem to an organization or institution. Students should carefully consult with their major professor and Academic Plan Committee to identify appropriate and feasible projects.

There is no specified length for the creative component report, but generally they are between 15 and 30 double-spaced pages, inclusive of notes, references, and appendices. The report should provide a justification for the project (including any relevant literature), a discussion of the methods used, a summary of the outcomes of the project, and a reflection on the significance of the project for the student's career goals.

- 4.3.3. Final Oral Examination:** Once all of the above requirements have been met, the Academic Plan Committee will administer a final oral examination to the student. This examination will last approximately two hours and may cover any aspects of the student's coursework or research, but the main emphasis will be on the student's thesis or creative component. Students must submit the Graduate Request for Oral Exam (https://iastate.service-now.com/esc?id=kb_article&sysparm_article=KB0022884) three weeks prior to the scheduled date of the exam. Additionally, each semester there are deadlines for the last day to take the Final Oral Examination, which are set by the Graduate College. When students have passed their Final Oral Examination, they must submit the Graduate Student Approval Form (which requires approval from the Academic Plan Committee and DOGE)(https://iastate.service-now.com/esc?id=kb_article&sysparm_article=KB0024340) by the deadline specified by the Graduate College. If any conditions were placed on the pass, the major professor must also submit an Oral Exam Conditions Met Request to the Graduate College in Workday indicating that all conditions for the pass have been met.

5. Student Progress and Evaluation

5.1. Teaching Assistant Evaluations

Each year all TAs will be evaluated by their supervising faculty member. If students are teaching a course that does not have a supervising faculty member, the Graduate Program Committee will designate a member of the committee who will review the student's teaching. These evaluations are meant to be formative—they provide faculty with an opportunity to discuss the strengths of TAs' performance and identify any areas that may need improvement as well as discuss ways to make those improvements. Evaluations should include at least one classroom visit to the recitation, lab, online course, or class taught by the TA. TAs receiving favorable performance reviews may continue teaching. For those who are in need of additional training, the TA will be directed to the Center for Excellence in Learning and Teaching (CELT) for additional formative teaching development or to another campus unit who offers similar opportunities to graduate student teachers. Negative teaching performance reviews can result in loss of the teaching assistantship.

5.2. Annual Progress Report

Each year all students will complete an annual report of their performance with their major professor. Students will report on their achievements for the year and progress on satisfying the degree requirements. Major professors will provide feedback on their students' progress, note areas of outstanding performance, and identify deficiencies as well as propose measures for addressing them. These evaluations will be conducted at the beginning of each student's second and fourth semesters. These evaluations are designed to foster open communication between graduate students and their major professors on key issues such as programmatic expectations, quality of work, and progress towards the degree.

5.3. Student Progress

The following is the preferred timeline for students to complete the MA degree in Anthropology with important milestones for each semester. This timeline does not include the completion of student research, which often is done during the breaks between semesters. The timeline also does not include additional certifications, minors, or degree programs that students may choose to pursue.

Semester 1

Submit and obtain approvals for Academic Plan Committee
Complete ANTHR 5030 or 5100

Semester 2

Complete ANTHR 5030 or ANTHR 5100
Complete methods requirement
Have research proposal accepted by Academic Plan Committee
Receive ethics approval for research (IRB and/or IACUC and/or RSC)

Semester 3

Complete ANTHR 5990 or 6990 requirement
Obtain final approval for any revisions to Academic Plan

Semester 4

Apply for Program Completion
Schedule and pass Final Oral Examination
Submit final approved thesis or creative component report to Graduate College

These guidelines are meant to provide students with a general outline of important milestones for planning and gauging their progress through the degree program. Students' progress towards completion of the degree will be evaluated periodically through the Annual Progress Reports outlined above.

If a major professor deems that a student is not making sufficient progress towards one or more of the degree requirements, the major professor will communicate this in the Annual Progress Report or in a written statement to the student and the DOGE, which specifies the following: a) the deficiency in the student's progress; b) what the student needs to do to correct the deficiency; c) the time period in which the deficiency must be corrected; and d) the penalty for not correcting

the deficiency. In most instances, if the student does not correct the deficiency in the time specified, the student will be dismissed following the procedures outlined in Section 8.7 of the Graduate College Handbook (<https://www.grad-college.iastate.edu/handbook/chapter8-responsibilities>). The student will have the opportunity to appeal according to the procedures laid out in the Graduate College Handbook in this same chapter.

Some indications that a student may not be making sufficient progress in the degree include, but are not limited to:

- Not submitting the membership of their Academic Plan Committee by the end of the second semester;
- Not completing ANTHR 5030 and 5100 by the end of the second semester;
- Not having a research proposal accepted by the end of the third semester;
- Not submitting a thesis draft or creative component draft report to the Academic Plan Committee by the end of the fourth semester;
- Not completing all degree requirements by the end of three years.

6. Graduate Student Rights and Responsibilities

All graduate student rights and responsibilities are outlined in detail in [Chapter 8 of the Graduate College Handbook](#) which includes important information about maintaining academic standing, student grievance procedures, and expectations for assistantship appointments. Students should review this information in detail. The MA program in Anthropology is committed to fostering a positive environment that is conducive to graduate student learning and success and follows all Graduate College policies and procedures.

7. Special Graduate Majors

Students pursuing graduate certificates, co-major degree programs, or concurrent graduate degree programs should carefully consult [Section 4.3 of the Graduate College Handbook](#) and also consult on a regular basis with their major professors and the DOGEs of their programs to ensure that they clearly understand the requirements for both programs and are making sufficient progress towards completing them.

8. Program Administration

The DOGE of the Anthropology graduate program must be a tenured graduate faculty member in the Anthropology section and will be appointed by the department chair in consultation with the Anthropology faculty. The DOGE administers the graduate program in consultation and with approval from the department chair and the anthropology graduate faculty.

All tenure-stream and tenured graduate faculty in the anthropology section who are not on leave will participate in the graduate applications review process. The review process will be led by the DOGE. In addition to reviewing and making recommendations on applications, the Anthropology Graduate Faculty will participate in student recruitment and retention and in the review and revision of the graduate curriculum, program handbook, and program forms.

Alterations to this handbook can be proposed by any member of the anthropology graduate faculty but must be approved by a majority vote of the anthropology graduate faculty.

9. Appendices

Additional resources are available for faculty and students to track progress and provide evaluation:

- Progress Report
- Academic Progress Timeline
- Teaching Assistant Evaluation Form
- ANTHR 5900 Independent Study Form